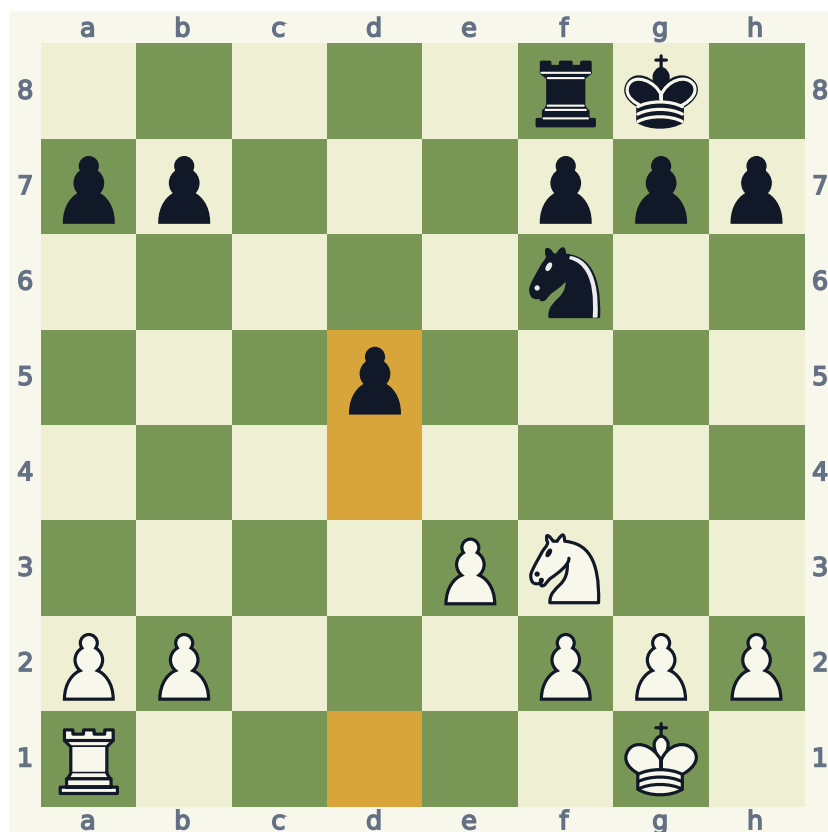


Weak pawns as targets

Fix the weakness, then build pressure.

An isolated pawn lacks friendly pawns on neighboring files. A backward pawn cannot safely advance and trails nearby friendly pawns. Doubled pawns share a file. These structures are not automatically bad: a weakness matters when it can be fixed, reached and attacked at a useful cost.

MODEL A | WHITE TO MOVE



READ THE POSITION

- Black's d5-pawn has no c- or e-pawn neighbor.
- The d-file gives White a direct route to the target.
- Nd4 would stop the pawn advancing to d4.

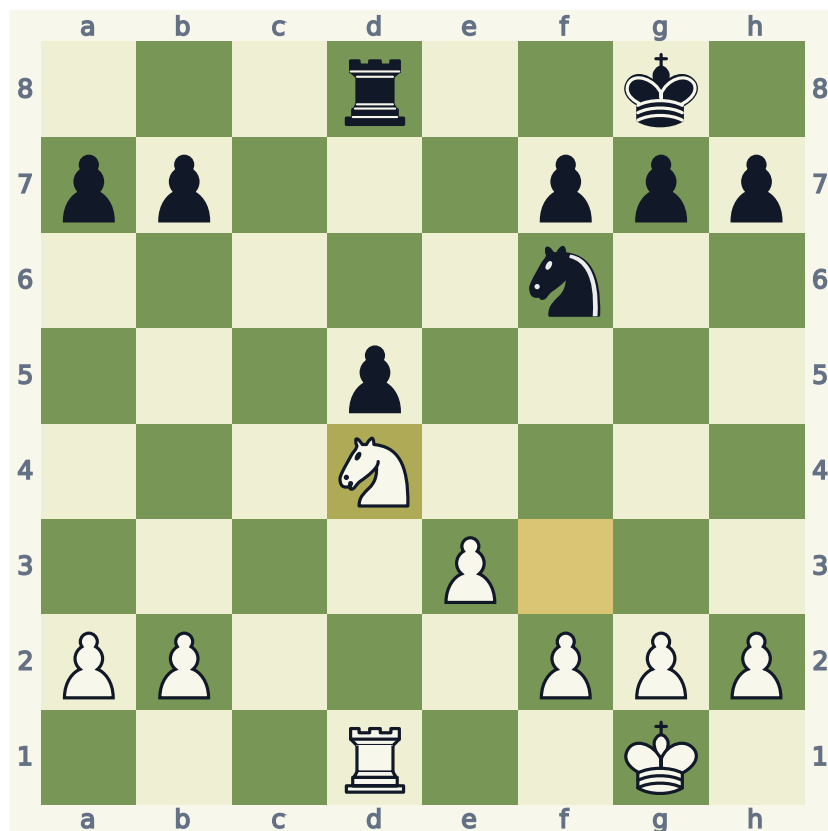
REMEMBER

- A structural label is not a verdict.
- Check whether the target can move.
- Fix, attack, and watch counterplay.

Follow the logic

1. Rd1 Rd8 2. Nd4

MODEL A | POSITION AFTER THE LINE



Rd1

Attack the isolated pawn along its file. The immediate objective is to make Black devote a piece to defense.

...Rd8

Black protects d5 with a rook. White has created pressure, but one attacker against one defender wins nothing.

Nd4

Blockade in front of the pawn. The knight is supported by e3 and prevents ...d4 from freeing Black's position.

THE OPPONENT'S PLAN

Black should seek active piece play or a timely ...d4 before the blockade is established. If White commits everything to d5, Black may create threats elsewhere and make the attack too slow.

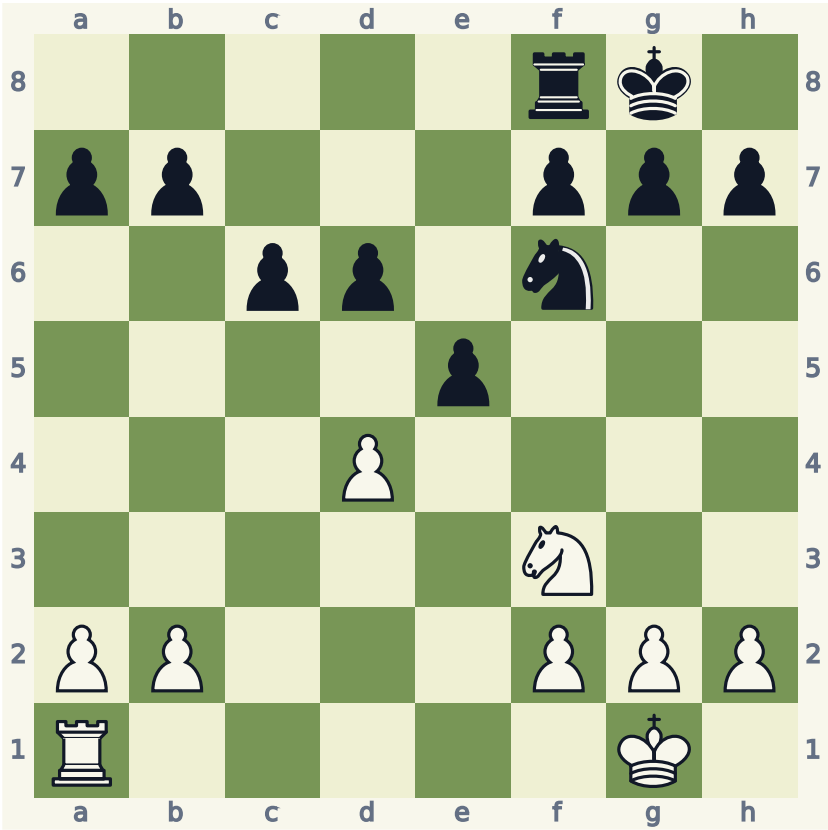
WHEN THE IDEA FAILS

Do not attack a pawn that can advance with tempo or be sacrificed for strong activity. A doubled pawn may control valuable squares and open a useful file for its own rook.

Find the plan

Set a timer for 6 minutes. Write the reasons, not just a move.

EXERCISE B | WHITE TO MOVE



- 1. Which pawn becomes the target after Rc1?
- 2. Can you prove that it is permanently weak?
- 3. What should White check before adding more pressure?

CHANGE ONE FEATURE

If Black's b7-pawn disappeared, how would c6 change?

YOUR PLAN, THE OPPONENT'S REPLY, AND THE RESULTING POSITION

Position code (FEN): 5rk1/pp3ppp/2pp1n2/4p3/3P4/5N2/PP3PPP/R5K1 w - - 0 1

Answers and transfer

1. Rc1 pressures c6, which is supported by b7. The target is defended, so attacking it once does not win it. White should examine the role of each pawn and piece defender.
2. No. Black may prepare ...c5, challenging d4 and changing the target. The label weak is provisional until you examine whether that advance is safe and whether White can keep the pawn fixed.
3. Check whether ...c5 can free the pawn and challenge d4. If White can fix c6 safely, pressure may tie Black down. If it cannot be fixed, the rook may need a different task instead of committing more time to a moving target.

ONE ILLUSTRATIVE LEGAL LINE

1. Rc1 Re8

Changed feature: It would lose its pawn defender. The c-file pressure would become more concrete, although Black could still defend c6 with a piece or use a timely ...c5 break.

APPLY IT TO YOUR GAMES

Find an isolated or doubled pawn in a game. List its benefits as well as its drawbacks before deciding whether to attack it.

Self-check: Award 0-2 points per numbered answer: 1 for the relevant fact, 1 for its consequence. Add 2 for the changed-feature answer. Revisit the lesson at 5/8 or below; repeat from memory tomorrow and one week later.

Related topics: 11, 15, 19. | Reference links and notation key: 00_Start_Here.pdf.